take time, however, so Gandhi defended continuing to resort to food aid from the US, noting that India had no other choice.

The Soviet Union, after all, had not been forthcoming on food aid.[158] Indeed, overall, the Soviet option had hardly been unproblematic—and definitely not an option that India could rely on alone. Foreign ministry officials worried about whether a leadership change in Beijing might lead to a Sino-Soviet rapprochement. They also watched with concern Soviet efforts "to become increasingly friendly towards Pakistan, to reduce that country's dependence on both the USA and China." The best the foreign minister could say internally about India-Soviet relations was that they "had not deteriorated."[159]

The prime minister's office and Chagla believed that it was a critical moment for the US-India relationship.[160] India continued to need the US, but American policymakers were questioning India's value and capability. Aware of the repercussions for India if the US lost interest completely, officials continued to try to "sell" India vis-à-vis China. When Rusk asked Chagla what India had done for the US lately, the foreign minister said, "by standing firm against China [India was] contributing towards countering [the] Chinese menace and thus helping in the containment of China which was also the United States aim."[161] Publicly, too, the foreign minister reiterated, "It was in the interest of the United States to keep India strong, for if India goes under then the lights of democracy will go out in the whole of Asia."[162]

Recognizing that India's value to Washington was due in no small part to China, Indian officials realized that a change in America's policy toward China could have an impact on India's place in US strategy. In his state of the union speech in January 1967, Johnson had indicated his "hope for a reconciliation between the people of Mainland China and the world community."[163] The possibility was debated in the Indian foreign ministry. The foreign minister noted the increasing sentiment in the American private sector to do business with China. He said that Beijing, on its part, might be motivated toward "getting closer" to the US because of its deteriorating relationship with the Soviet Union. The foreign secretary mentioned Japanese reports that the Chinese foreign minister desired a rapprochement with the US. He thought that once the Vietnam War was over, this would be much more likely. Jagat Mehta, the policy-planning chief, was skeptical,